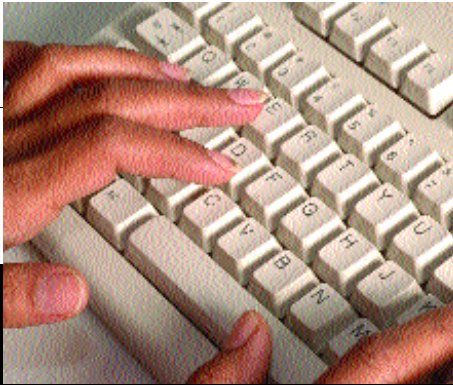




Write to the Editor

E-mail: editor@thinkdigit.com

Snail Mail: The Editor, Digit, D-222/2, Om Sagar Building, MIDC, TTC Industrial Estate, Nerul, Navi Mumbai 400 706

Digit will publish the best letters on these pages. Letters may be edited for clarity

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Bust The Google Myth

On Page 81 of the February 2005 issue of *Digit*, in the story relating to Gmail, the Web site address provided in Step 1 was incorrect. The correct address is www.viksoe.dk, and not www.viskoe.dk as mentioned.

But that is not the real reason for writing this mail. The media the world over goes gaga whenever Google does something. It may have been justified at one point of time. Not any more. Google may have become synonymous with online search, but if Microsoft's beta version of search is anything to go by, then hard days are up ahead for Google.

Search for any term on both Google and MSN, and check the results for the following:

- ☑ Number of results generated
- ☑ Relevance of the results
- ☑ Speed of loading the page
- ☑ Last updated date of the cached version of the page



Is MSN Search really better than Google?

The truth is that MSN wins hands down in most cases. I am no MSN junkie nor am I being paid by Microsoft to write this mail. I also know there are a lot of people who swear by Google, and will vehemently disagree with me on this. So, how about checking it out on your own?

Maybe Google could strengthen its search capabilities, and retain its No 1 position.

Ramanpreet Singh
New Delhi

Dear Ramanpreet,
Cola wars are part of advertising and marketing folklore. The 21st century's online history could well begin with the war of the searches. With Google, MSN and Yahoo vying online for a piece of the search pie, it is only logical that all three players come out with more and more innovative products every month. While most people at *Digit* prefer Google, we are not loyalists. If a better search engine comes along, we will hop there. Having said that, we just cannot take Google lightly. After all, it has some of the world's best software engineers and leaders including Sergey Brin, Larry Page and Eric Schmidt heading its dynamic team. Our opinion is, don't write off Google just yet.

—Executive Editor

Some Random Observations

Digit's December and January issue were simply great! Thank you for the Encyclopaedia Britannica Concise Edition CD. It was a pure treat to read all the gadget reviews, and I even got to learn a lot about Formula 3, courtesy the race driver Karun Chandok. The story on Jagdeep Dangi and his Hindi browser was unique, and was a positive piece on how one can overcome challenges to succeed in life.

When I read the piece I wondered why Indian technology biggies do not come out with affordable software products for the Indian market. Given their expertise and financial prowess, they could easily give even the giant Microsoft a run for its money, and greatly help in reducing piracy due to cheaper software.



Digit: navigating you through more than just tech

I have a similar opinion about hardware. Unless India gets manufacturing plants to produce all the components of a PC here, I doubt whether we will be able to achieve the sub-Rs 10,000 PC dream.

Let's hope that we see a day when affordable computing becomes a reality.

Nitin

Via E-mail

Dear Nitin,
Your observations are well thought-out and perceptive. It is indeed a paradox as to why India supplies some of the world's best customised software to various countries, but has no product to show off for the domestic market. Perhaps the day will come soon when we will be able to assemble sub-Rs 10,000 PCs in India.

—Executive Editor

Apple Of My Eye

I learn, breathe and sleep design at the National Institute of Design (NID), Ahmedabad. I may not be a technologist anymore, but I have to deal with it in every product, which I design or think of.

For years, *Digit* had been my 'navigator for technology', and it continues to be so for me, a loyal subscriber, even after that 'sensible' decision I took to leave all the so-called service packs, patches, blue screens, and viruses behind and switch over to the Apple Macintosh!

As expected from the Mac cult, it is not just brand loyalty that prompts me to write this mail. The "Old Way Tech Way" article comparing an iPod with the Walkman (*Digit*, February 2005) does no justice to the Apple product.

Admittedly, the Walkman was a revolution when it was introduced. It created a new concept of carrying music; but so did iPod change the way people buy and share music. Even Steve Jobs might not have anticipated that music could bring more revenue for Apple than all their products put together.

Does *Digit* really feel your brand head's Walkman deserved a smiley face for that it takes more than an hour to load a 20-song playlist compared to less than half an hour the executive editor took to import your entire music collection for life to an iPod? Or do you feel the total cost of Rs 1,055 for only 20 songs is much cheaper than Rs 15,000 for 3,000 songs? I guess the total cost for the Walkman didn't consider the cost for hiring a truck to carry the entire music collection as audio tapes!

It is a wrong to say that Apple product owners are only show-offs; the user-experience that one goes through can never be replaced by anything else! I did not expect *Digit* to make a comparison based only on someone's personal views.

Nithin Ismail
Ahmedabad

LETTER
OF THE
MONTH